

REVEALING Windows

If you have wished for more control over who can access your PC or your data, the first solution would have been to switch over to Windows 2000 or XP. But you can have security in Windows 98 too

Every Windows user unwittingly leaves his or her PC naked to prying eyes. It doesn't take a programmer or cracker to get to your computer. Keys are left in every door and windows (no pun intended) are well oiled to make it simpler. Microsoft quietly assumed that 'desktop users' would never have the need for security and unabashedly discarded all such features from its 'home user operating systems', as against the server OSes.

This does not mean that we have to continue to pay for the oversight of the software giant. We can take our own steps to safeguard our PCs and data. Here are some of the most blatant security lapses and workarounds for the weaknesses.

Windows login

The Windows login is the worst pseudo security measure—by itself, it simply cannot prevent unauthorised access to your computer. Microsoft designed the

operating system for just desktop PCs, and assumed that security was required only for servers. Thus, the Windows login only loads the correct desktop settings and can be bypassed by simply pressing [Esc]. There are some ways to make it more secure, though these are not the most elegant solutions. Still, it will take more than just a little effort to bypass these.

First, configure your Windows for multiple users from **Control Panel > Users**. Create

a new user by typing a new name at the Windows login box, then restart Windows and login as the new user. Open the registry by running **regedit** from **Start > Run** and navigate to **HKEY_Users\Default\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Run**. If the Run key does not exist, create it. Create a new string value named **LockEscape**, and set its value to **rundll32 shell32,SHExitWindowsEx 0**. Now when you log off or restart the machine, you can login as the new user created, but if the Cancel button or the [Esc] key is pressed, the desktop will partially load and then return to the login screen. Optionally, you could set the PC to shut down upon unauthorised access, but this can get very irritating. To do this, use the command **rundll.exe user.exe,ExitWindows** as the value for the registry key.

This method basically takes advantage of the Windows architecture. When logging in as a particular user, Windows loads the user's profile with Desktop settings,



Set up multiple users on Windows